Hauntology, Ruins, and the Failure of the Future in Andrei Tarkovsky's *Stalker*

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THIS ARTICLE PROPOSES THAT A HAUNTOLOGICAL APPROACH to the study of Andrei Tarkovsky's *Stalker* (1979) can deepen our understanding of the issues that the film raises. My broader contention is that each of Tarkovsky's films invites a thorough hauntological consideration. Here, however, I will use *Stalker* as a case study. I will explain how the film, traditionally understood as an allegory about faith, is not only a cinematic representation of the failure of the promised Soviet future to arrive but also a still-pertinent guide to our present moment.[1]

In Tarkovsky's cinema, there are near-literal ghosts, such as the inexplicably resurrected Theophanes in *Andrei Rublev* (1968) and the revenant version of Hari in *Solaris* (1972). A full hauntological interpretation of Tarkovsky's cinema would give due consideration to these specters. Here, though, I will prioritize the kind of cinematic ghost that, as proposed by Alexander Etkind, "lives" within texts (Etkind, "Post Soviet Hauntology" 182–200).

A hauntological critique of Tarkovsky's cinema is necessary at this juncture because criticism and interpretation of Tarkovsky's work has been guided, overshadowed, and often limited by Tarkovsky's own words and the traditional aesthetic values he upheld, especially as outlined in his book *Sculpting in Time*. Since this paradigm has become entrenched, it has occasionally been criticized: Tarkovsky scholar Robert Bird dealt with this overreliance on "the intentional fallacy," arguing that scholars should focus on the "manifest discontinuities" in Tarkovsky's work instead of "incorporating them within the hermetic continuities of an allegorical narrative" (Bird, "Gazing into Time"). However, since Bird's work in 2003, scholars have done little to attend to these discontinuities and ambiguities, which permeate Tarkovsky's cinema. Hauntology, with its focus on spectral traces and uncanny discontinuities, can fix our attention on these moments and help us to determine how they are relevant to our ongoing sociopolitical moment. In order to demonstrate this, I will first turn to the theoretical construct of hauntology to provide the necessary contextual information.

Jacques Derrida coined the wry neologism "hauntology" in *Spectres of Marx*, a work that aimed to rekindle the spirit of the Marxist international against the triumphalist rhetoric of the early 1990s, following the fall of the Berlin Wall. This triumphalism was encapsulated by the neoliberal theorist Francis Fukuyama's notion of the "end of history." Fukuyama saw history as a process of competing ideologies, which the dissolution of the Soviet Union had brought to an end. Derrida wanted to show the brutal side effects of unchecked free-market capitalism and to demonstrate that ideas thought to be buried would keep returning, albeit as specter-like traces.

To explore this idea of revisitations from the past, Derrida returns, throughout the linked

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essays that make up *Spectres of Marx*, to two main motifs from Shakespeare's *Hamlet*. First, he analyzes the figure of the ghost, whom he links to the "spectre of communism" cited by Marx. Second, Derrida seizes upon Hamlet's pronouncement that "the time is out of joint," suggesting provocatively that this disjointed time is the political situation that must be set right, the debt that we must settle. Derrida's hauntology, then, is not only a way of conceptualizing our repressed past but also a way of understanding our obsession with failed futures; the gleaming Soviet dream failed to manifest itself, but the forward march of progress promised by capitalism is continually halted by financial crises, interethnic wars, terrorism, and other chaotic conditions.

Since Derrida's book appeared in the early 1990s, the term "hauntology" has taken on a life of its own (perhaps an afterlife?). The concept has bled out of academia, inspiring musical and visual artists in addition to scholars.[2] Inspired by Derrida, Alexander Etkind's work examines the ways in which post-Soviet Russian culture has attempted to memorialize the victims of the Stalinist terror through monuments, films, and so on. Etkind argues that Russia has yet to find adequate cultural processes to mourn and commemorate these past tragedies. Out of this investigation comes his theory of cultural memory, which he develops using a computer analogy; hardware is formed by monuments, software by texts, and ghostware by uncanny traces within those texts. Etkind explains:

> Usually, ghosts live in texts; sometimes, they inhabit cemeteries and emerge from monuments. Most often, ghosts appear before the living whose dead were not properly buried. Ghosts feature interesting differences from texts and monuments. Texts are symbolic, while ghosts are iconic in the semiotic sense of these terms (as signs, ghosts possess a visual resemblance to the signified); in contrast to monuments, texts and ghosts are ephemeral; and in contrast to texts and monuments, ghosts are uncanny. (Etkind, "Post-Soviet Hauntology" 195)

Cinema itself is particularly apt to contain these uncanny specters because, as Derrida himself observed, "cinema is the science of ghosts."[3] The ghosts that Etkind finds in post-Soviet cinema are themes displayed in both art-house films and popular genre movies that deal with unburied or ghostly figures that need to be laid to rest. *Stalker*, though from the Soviet era, mobilizes ghosts that are traces of a repressed past and of a promised but aborted future through the film's use of science fiction tropes and supernatural imagery.

Tarkovsky's films, I want to suggest, are implicitly Cold War films. His debut film, *Ivan's Childhood* (1963), arose from the fractious political atmosphere of the Soviet Thaw, his career matured during the long stagnation of the Brezhnev period, and audiences in both the East and West viewed his films against the backdrop of the Cold War. His final two films were made in Italy and Sweden after a much-publicized defection that is usually conceived of as an "exile" by his most fervent admirers, intent on hagiography.[4] The films themselves are rarely discussed in this context because, as I have stated, discourse around Tarkovsky's films has so often been guided by parameters he set himself.

In the course of developing a theory of Tarkovsky's "creative anxiety," Vladimir Golstein remarks that "Tarkovsky continues to be appreciated for a number of reasons that no longer appear convincing" (177). The ideological charge of the Cold War has gone, and the high-art values Tarkovsky championed have been largely replaced by knowing irony and pastiche in both popular cinema and contemporary fine art. Glossing Golstein's original assertion, J. Hoberman summarizes, "Back in the '60s and '70s, Tarkovsky was a hero of cold-war artistic dissidence for some, while at the same time living proof that only the state would subsidize so trippy a countercultural genius."

It is my contention that the context in which Tarkovsky's films were made has not entirely gone away; in fact, it still exists in new, transfigured forms. Consequently, Tarkovsky's films are still needed, not as bulwarks of conservative

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aesthetics but as guides through our complex subjective responses to the geopolitical situation.

The initial breakup of the Soviet Union resulted not only in massive economic turbulence and civil disturbance but also in the creation of thousands of miles of new national borders, sometimes facilitating autonomy and sometimes leading to the eruption of violent conflict.[5] One further result of these new borders has been the emergence of several partially recognized breakaway states such as those in the Caucasus and Transnistria. Russia's involvement in the Crimea crisis, beginning in February 2014, has highlighted in the public consciousness the idea of a "Cold War 2.0" This fractious geopolitical situation never quite went away, needing only the right conditions to bring it back into sharp focus.

As Edith W. Clowes explains, "in distinction to Soviet identity, which was temporally defined—linked to a vision of the Soviet state at the vanguard of history—the post-Soviet debate about Russian identity has been couched in spatial metaphors of territory and geography" (Clowes xi). Clowes's assertion is relevant to *Stalker* in two ways: the film deals obliquely with a future that never arrives and directly with the complications and possibilities of the sudden appearance of a new border.

Mystically inclined admirers of Tarkovsky like to note that he "foretold" the Chernobyl disaster in *Stalker*.[6] In another, less paranormal sense, we can conceptualize *Stalker* as a foretelling, or foreshadowing, of these new national partitions that were imposed in the wake of the Soviet Union's collapse. The themes of death and return, failed futures, military and industrial catastrophes, exile, and nostalgia, which dominate Tarkovsky's films, continue to be relevant in this reconfigured geopolitical landscape.[7]

Every film is, in some sense, about the culture and era that spawned it. Tarkovsky's career, spanning East and West at the time of the Cold War, encapsulates its historical moment, even when it appears not to. Wim Wenders seems to have realized this about Tarkovsky, borrowing some of the angelic imagery from *Nostalghia* (1983) and giving the Russian director an onscreen dedication in his film *Wings of Desire* (1987), a film that interposes mystical imagery into a story that foregrounds Berlin's division by the Berlin Wall. *Wings of Desire*, like *Stalker*, posits a split between two realities, the sacred and the profane, rendered in monochrome and color. In *Wings of Desire* the elderly poet Homer (Curt Bois) roams the streets of Berlin, perhaps seeking an artistic epiphany or moment of nostalgic transcendence, but finds only a partition: the graffiti-covered Berlin Wall.

The cultures of post-Soviet Russia and modern Germany share a question, the question of how to remember, memorialize, or forget a troubling past. Perhaps Wenders understood that it was not Chernobyl that Tarkovsky foretold with *Stalker*. It was the ongoing relevance of the border, the zone, and our uneasy relation to our collective past.



Figure 1: Tarkovsky's aesthetics meet the Berlin Wall in *Wings of Desire* (Wim Wenders, 1987).

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A brief description of *Stalker*'s plot can barely convey the experience of watching the film: the hypnotic experience created by the immersive soundtrack and the complex tracking shots of transfigured talismans of ruins. It is ostensibly a science fiction story in which a supernatural, extraterrestrial, or sublime visitation has left a portion of Earth as a place in which the usual laws of reality no longer apply. The authorities have cordoned off this zone, and rumors begin to spread that it contains a room capable of making manifest people's subconscious desires. The profession of "stalking" has developed to guide travelers past the military cordon and through the transfigured landscape of the zone to this wish-granting room. The film begins as the eponymously titled Stalker (Aleksandr Kaidanovsky) prepares to guide two men, known as the Writer (Anatoly Solonitsyn) and the Professor (Nikolai Grinko), into the heavily guarded zone and toward the room.

Since *Stalker* debuted on Soviet screens in 1979 (reaching the West by the early 1980s), a genre known as "ruin porn" has grown up independently in photography and other visual arts. Ruin porn is the aestheticization of urban and industrial decay, and although *Stalker* predates this trend, it must be admitted that some of *Stalker*'s subsequent critical success and its elevation to an art-house staple and "cult" film must be seen in the context of this trend's ascendancy. However Tarkovsky intended the film to be understood, the ascendancy of ruin porn has provided an aesthetic framework for appreciation of the film. It is in the context of ruin porn that critic Evan Calder Williams, charging that the film is an empty aestheticization of decay, has called it "a consummate film of the broken world's loveliness"[8] (Williams 160).

Ruin porn's "porn" component can be understood in a number of ways. It can refer to the unadulterated aesthetic pleasure audiences get from these photographs. It also can be understood more critically, perhaps pejoratively; ruin porn's critics perceive it as being devoid of commentary, seemingly driven only by a voyeuristic desire to trespass beyond the "no entry" signs and explore and capture these dilapidated ruins.[9] Finally, it can be understood as a reference to the guilt that comes from enjoying the exploitation of failed economies for aesthetic pleasure of the elite.

Although ruin porn has given Western audiences an aesthetic framework to the appreciation of *Stalker*, in the process helping it to achieve its status as a cult film, the criticisms leveled against the film show an unwillingness to engage with ruins and decay as an aesthetic and thematic strategy that is explicitly hauntological. Hauntological texts, as Mark Fisher notes, fixate on texts that depict "landscapes stained by time," places where, as in *Hamlet*, "time is out of joint" (Fisher, "What Is Hauntology?" 21). *Stalker* is a manifestation of a peculiar kind of disjointed time and stained place, for three reasons: a ruined landscape, a science fiction turn to the past, and the notion of a supernatural zone itself.

A landscape littered with ruins is a landscape stained by time. The industrial ruins seen in *Stalker* are a trace of the economic stagnation that had set into the Soviet Union by the Brezhnev era. Both the monochrome world of decaying bars, railway sidings, and barbed wire and the colorful, verdant, waterlogged world inside the zone are full of decaying and ruined buildings.

Because ruins are largely unintentional, they can become a monument to failure. In this way, they form part of the "hardware" of cultural memory that Etkind proposes. Etkind compares monuments to "crystals that settle in a solution of memory" ("Warped Mourning" 176). In Russia, where monuments to Soviet repressions are rare—often makeshift affairs erected unofficially by relatives of the deceased—ruins can also take on the role of monuments (Etkind, "Warped Mourning" 171–95).

"Monuments without texts are mute, while texts without monuments are ephemeral," Etkind explains ("Warped Mourning" 177). It should also be added that ruins are ephemeral without texts. In *Stalker*, the ruins are those of an Estonian factory and two hydroelectric plants on the outskirts of Talinn. On their own, these abandoned structures are incredibly ephemeral,

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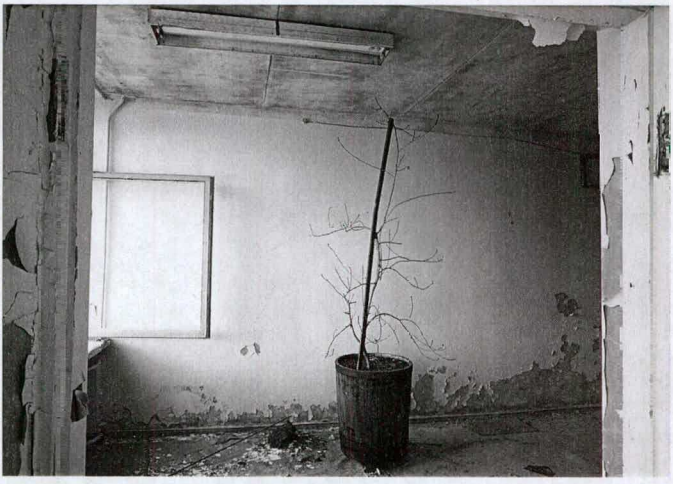


Figure 2: Photography from Chernobyl that recalls the imagery from inside Tarkovsky's zone. "Hotel Landing, Pripyat" from the series "Legacy: Inside the Chernobyl Exclusion Zone." ©John Darwell, 1999. Used with permission.



Figure 3: The ruined interior of the zone in *Stalker* (Andrei Tarkovsky, 1979).

perhaps just contingent. But captured by the camera, they take on further significance—mummified but also transfigured.

German sociologist Georg Simmel argued that ruins are made significant by the creative force of nature acting upon them. The verdant but subtly malevolent force of nature is everywhere inside the zone. *Stalker*'s visual landscape represents a natural world that industrialization is incapable of industrializing, a landscape that modernization can no longer modernize. This is how *Stalker* articulates the failure of the future to arrive. Simmel's notion is borne out by the Stalker's revelatory experience, which happens as he lies down in the grass. I will now turn my attention to this sequence.

When the Stalker first arrives back in the zone, he leaves his two charges to recline on the grass, and while he is seemingly in an intensely meditative state, Edward Artemyev's distinctive theme music plays on the soundtrack. As soon as we arrive in the zone then, the film foregrounds the notion that ruined buildings, overrun with grass, lichen, and other signifiers of the natural world, are the site of meditative, uncanny, and epiphanic experiences.

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After a lengthy discussion the Professor insists that he will wait for the Stalker and the Writer to return from the room, and he sits down bathetically with his sandwiches and a thermos to wait for them to return. But when the Stalker and the Writer arrive at a half-demolished building, its tiled interior still visible, covered with moss and lichen, the Professor has somehow found his way ahead of them. In the zone, a world of verdant ruins, space is no longer linear but circular.

The Stalker takes the opportunity of this reunion to lie down in the grass again, and the sequence known unofficially as "the Stalker's dream" begins. The footage switches to sepia, and the camera is above the Stalker, regarding his face. It then begins to track vertically across the water by his head. Submerged in the water is a mass of debris: a silver plate; a syringe; coins; a panel from Jan Van Eyck's *Ghent Altarpiece* depicting John the Baptist, covered in silt and with a leaf floating above it; a gun; and glimpses of a black-and-white ceramic tiled floor. All assume an eerie, oneiric quality. Then we return to the Stalker again, impossibly lying further upstream than when we first saw him.

The Stalker's experience of the zone, a place of ruins intertwined with nature, provokes an experience of disjointed but circular space and time. But is this an experience the Stalker perceives within the diegesis, or does Tarkovsky orchestrate it for our benefit? Among the ruins of Soviet industrial expansion, boundaries between the subjective and objective blur, and time seems to stretch and contract. Thus are Tarkovskian ruins places "stained by time," where "time is out of joint" and where an experience of the oneiric is possible both for characters and for willing audiences.

Related to this oneiric experience of ruins is *Stalker*'s turn away from futuristic iconography and toward a disjointed version of an earlier era. *Stalker* is ostensibly a science fiction story. In fact, it starkly dramatizes the failure of the future to appear. Soviet conceptions of the future fixated upon space travel, starting with the mythologizing of sputnik satellites and Yuri Gagarin. Svetlana Boym writes of the "miniature rockets found rusting in the children's playgrounds" of St. Petersburg, noting that these date from a time when "the future seemed unusually bright and the march of progress triumphant" (Boym 345–46). The future that failed to materialize, lamented here by Boym, is something that was promised, in different ways, by both sides of the Cold War conflict. Indeed, such prophecies were probably spurred on by the geopolitical impasse.

The iconography of space travel and science fiction had been inscribed in the Soviet imaginary since *Sputnik-1* was launched in 1957. Tarkovsky chose to make two science fiction films (the first being *Solaris*) precisely because this preexisting world of imagery and its association with Soviet progress allowed him to work in a context easily understood and appreciated by Soviet authorities.[10] However, by the time *Stalker* was finally released, Tarkovsky and his scriptwriters (the Strugatsky brothers, who were adapting their own novel) had removed almost all the tropes and iconography of science fiction; in their place was a focus on the decaying, the rusting, and the ruined.

The Strugatsky brothers' source novel strongly suggests a future world. But Tarkovsky's visual conception of this world eschews futurism, suggesting instead the past. It offers a similar monochrome aesthetic to Alexei German's *My Friend Ivan Lapshin* (1984), recalling monochrome photographs of a more austere era, the Stalinist 1930s—fraught with repression, conspiracy, and instability.

The language used in the film backs up these visual allusions. Geoff Dyer, in his personal memoir of watching *Stalker*, notes that the terms "zone" and "meat-grinder" were used during the Soviet era to refer to the Gulag.[11] He concludes, "*Stalker* is not a film *about* the Gulag, but the absent and unmentioned Gulag is constantly suggested, either by the Stalker's zek haircut or by the overlapping vocabulary" (Dyer 39).

Stalker takes place in a world, then, whose development seems to have been arrested during the 1930s, never progressing into the shiny future promised by the Soviet imaginary or even

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really into the late 1970s when the film was actually made. The film is haunted, or stalked, by the prewar Soviet era and by the legacy of the Gulag. This era constantly makes itself felt through Tarkovsky's banishment of modern or futuristic trappings from the mise-en-scène and his emphasis instead upon the antiquated and upon objects and linguistic terms that recall the Stalinist 1930s.

The paranormal visitation that has cleft the world in two (to borrow a phrase from Maya Turovskaya's essay on Tarkovsky's debut film) also creates disjointed place and time. This is conveyed to the viewer through the simple technique of switching from monochrome to color when the three men enter the zone.

However, when we first see the military cordon, we are reminded of the Berlin checkpoint in *The Spy Who Came in from the Cold* (Martin Ritt, 1965). Are the three men making a kind of defection as they frantically avoid the guards shooting at them? It is worth noting that although Tarkovsky carefully crafted the image of an aloof auteur above the dirty business of commercial filmmaking, he had seemingly uncharacteristic moments of praise for and involvement with commercial films, even citing *The Terminator* (1984) and, further, writing the script for an Uzbek thriller called *Beware Snakes!* (Zakir Sabitov, 1979). Within a film where Tarkovsky instructed his scriptwriters to remove all traces of typical science fiction tropes, the zone's border, with its crash-helmeted guards, machine-gun lookout posts, and barbed wire, seems like a deliberate and almost ludic use of Cold War spy-film iconography.

As the men progress through the zone, the dialogue begins to make clear that the journey we are seeing is an echo of an earlier journey made by a previous stalker called Porcupine. Porcupine believed that his desire was for something arguably unattainable without supernatural intervention: world peace. To attain this, he sacrificed his brother to one of the zone's spectral traps but then found that his real desires were not so noble. On leaving the zone, he found that he'd become incredibly wealthy, and he committed suicide, overcome with shame.

This earlier journey, by Porcupine and his brother, is like a ghost haunting the current expedition. This grim story is what ultimately persuades the Writer and Professor to abstain from entering the room (the room itself, demarcated by walls, is yet another border, this time right in the heart of the zone). This is the "fatal repetition" that Fisher notes in places stained by time.

It is also worth noting that Tarkovsky rejected the label "dissident" even after his defection to the West. "I have remained a Soviet artist and I shall remain one," he wrote in his last letter to his father, penned shortly before his defection (Tarkovsky, "The Last Letter to Father"). To paint *Stalker* as an anti-Soviet fable, therefore, would be reductive.[12] However, what *Stalker* does is register a broken time in which the ghosts from the repressed past and the failed future can return. The film's utilization of ruins goes beyond mere aestheticization of decay, as critics such

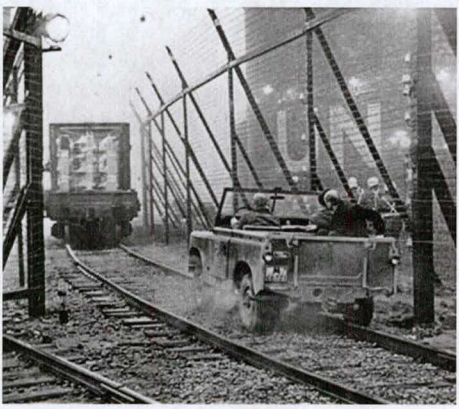


Figure 4: The three men try to cross the military cordon and enter the zone, in a moment pregnant with Cold War imagery in *Stalker* (Andrei Tarkovsky, 1979).

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as Jameson and Williams have claimed, to present both a repressed past and a failed future. The confluence of these fractured timelines and oneiric places makes *Stalker* a powerful hauntological text.

As past partitions in the former Soviet Union continue to make themselves felt, and the promised future of unchallenged liberal democracy makes itself conspicuous by its absence, Tarkovsky's films, far from being sidelined by the ending of the Cold War, as Golstein has implied, now take on their full significance as a result of its passing. Our ongoing obsession with promised futures that never seem to arrive and with borders and zones ensures that Tarkovsky's films are still relevant and essential.

NOTES

1. For typical interpretations of *Stalker*, see the director's own comments in Tarkovsky, *Sculpting in Time* (198–99), or Green, *Andrei Tarkovsky: The Winding Quest*.

2. For a consideration of musical artists such as The Caretaker and Burial alongside critical pieces on film and television, see Fisher, *The Ghosts of My Life*.

3. Derrida asserts this in an interview in the film *Ghost Dance* (Ken McMullen, 1983): "The modern technology of images . . . enhances the power of ghosts and their ability to haunt us," he continues.

4. For writing representative of this approach, see, for example, Alexander-Garrett, *Andrei Tarkovsky: The Collector of Dreams*.

5. For an account of these issues, see Walker, *Dissolution: Sovereignty and the Breakup of the Soviet Union*.

6. For a typical example, see Tyrkin.

7. International relations scholar Cerwyn Moore approaches it from the opposite angle, arguing that Tarkovsky's cinema sheds light on "often-neglected aspects of the political, such as the sublime, the revelatory, the confessional, which all play a role in the psyche of both culture and global politics" (Moore 75).

8. Evan Calder Williams opposes the uncritical aestheticization of urban decay with his own concept of "salvagepunk."

9. In his essay "The Forgetting Machine," Jerry Herron critiques ruin porn in terms that are remarkably similar to Williams's and Jameson's response to *Stalker*:

> A sense of "bogus religiosity," to use another of Berger's terms, pervades the images; action is foreclosed, except for the connoisseur-like contemplations of the solitary spectator, who is freed to look at the worst, without any necessity of further exertion. The "naked" facts of Detroit, in all their frightening and accusatory detail, are turned into museum-piece "nudes," spot-lit on the gallery walls; they're titillating perhaps, but also unreal, just like a centerfold image is unreal; and the more gorgeous, the better.

10. For a discussion of how Tarkovsky chose the relative safety of *Solaris* after his previous film *Andrei Rublev* ran into protracted difficulties with the Soviet authorities, see Bird, *Tarkovsky* 44.

11. For example, see Erkki Vetenniemi's *Surviving the Soviet Meat Grinder*.

12. For an example of just such a reductive reading, see Schreck.

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